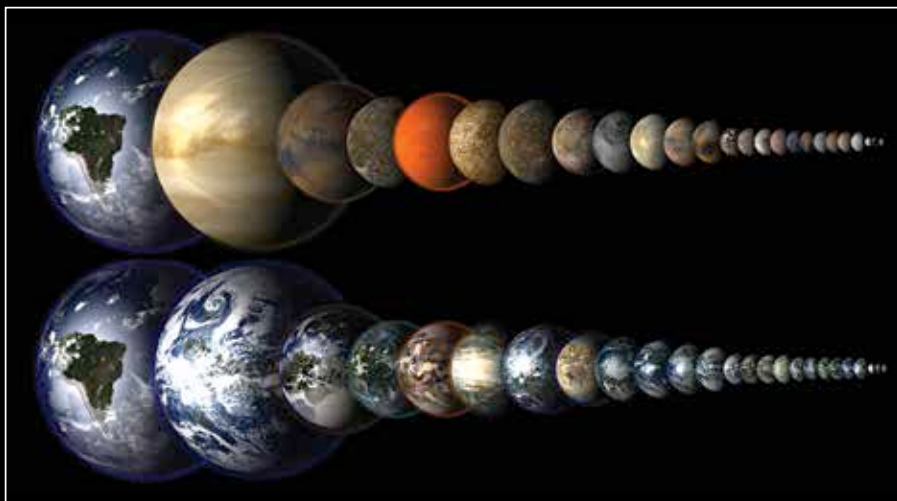




World's Largest Aquatic Insect

The world's largest aquatic insect with a wingspan of 21 centimetres has been found in China
<http://dgit.in/LargestInsect>

Space Age



Can we convert a desolate landscape into paradise?

Sun. The three essential goals to begin such a process are - the enhancement of its atmosphere, increase in temperatures and preserving the atmosphere from being lost to space. Scientists have already developed a number of practical and theoretical methods of creating an atmosphere on Mars and increasing its temperature.

Techniques such as the sublimation conversion of south pole ice would give the planet the atmosphere comparable to the peak of Mount Everest. Other ways like introducing ammonia to the atmosphere or various hydrocarbons or chlorofluorocarbons to increase the greenhouse effect have also clearly been outlined. An intriguing method is that of introducing a variety of extremophile lifeforms like lichens, algae and bacteria to the planet that would convert the carbon dioxide to carbohydrates exhaling oxygen into the

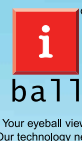
atmosphere. Some of the more radical methods include the use of orbital mirrors to increase the total insolation the planet receives or by directing small asteroids to Mars to increase temperatures. In all cases the ultimate challenge remains that without a dense enough atmosphere any gases released would be lost to space.

Imagining a new home

For many people the challenges and sheer enormity of attempting terraforming seems like a futile effort. None of the processes and technologies that are truly within reach hold any short-term feasibility, with even the most optimistic estimates requiring nearly three hundred years of continuous effort. Most people would call it impossible. But it is worthwhile to remember that if someone had told Misao Okawa on her 16th birthday that she would live to see a world where that derives its energy from the sun and the atom, or that humanity sends probes to interstellar space looking for habitable planets or that she would live to be 116 years old she would most likely have said they were imagining things - and she would be right - but that doesn't make it impossible. After all the first step towards accomplishing an impossible task is believing it's possible - then it's all about developing the innovation and technology necessary. With the very existence of humanity at stake we can expect the dream of discovering, settling and building new worlds to soon become a casual reality. 



Are we ready to say goodbye yet?



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